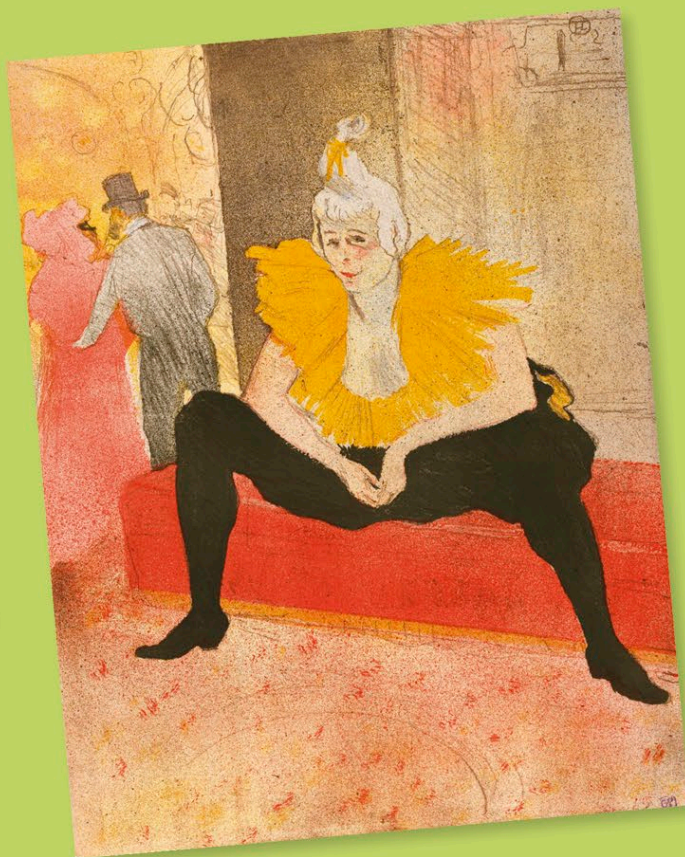




► **Bohemian icon**

The Seated Clowness by French painter Henri de Toulouse-Lautrec depicts dancing clown Cha-u-kao, who performed at the Moulin Rouge in the 1890s. She dressed in men's clothes and was openly lesbian.

THROUGH THE AGES

LGBTQ women

Stories of LGBTQ women in history are relatively few and far between. Many cultures have punished or ignored women who pushed against sexual and gender norms, meaning that before the 20th century, such women's lives frequently remained hidden under the radar.

“If you **forget me**, think of **our gifts to Aphrodite** and all the **loveliness** that **we shared** ... violet tiaras, braided **rosebuds** ...”

SAPPHO, LYRIC POET, “I HAVE NOT HAD ONE WORD FROM HER,” 6TH CENTURY BCE

WOMEN WHO ARE ATTRACTED to women; who were assigned male at birth; or who otherwise fall under the modern term “LGBTQ” (lesbian, gay, bisexual, and transgender) have always existed, yet their lives and experiences have rarely found their way into history books. It is only in the 20th century that LGBTQ women's histories have begun to be told, but in many cases, they rely on hearsay due to the lack of concrete evidence.

Hidden histories

Accounts of female homosexuality date back to the ancient world, in societies on every continent. Greek poet Sappho (see pp. 24–27) wrote about her desire for another woman, and in the 11th century, the rabbi Maimonides ordered men to keep their wives away from women who wished to sleep with them. Many cultures did not outlaw homosexual sex until the medieval period (in Europe) or later, and even then, in most societies male homosexuals bore the brunt of punishments.

In Europe and the US in the 18th and 19th centuries, it was not unusual for women to form close friendships in which they lived

together, traveled together, and wrote letters expressing their love for each other. Such “romantic friendships” were fashionable, but in some cases, girls were separated by their parents when their relationships became seen to be too intimate. In 18th-century Ireland, Lady Eleanor Butler and Sarah Ponsonby ran away to Wales together after their parents tried to keep them apart, becoming known as the Ladies of Llangollen. Their diaries attest to the fact that they shared a bed and dressed as